

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 674

By Butler

A RESOLUTION commemorating the fiftieth anniversary of the end of the Vietnam War.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly should commemorate those solemn events in our nation's history that recognize the sacrifices made by our veterans on behalf of their fellow Americans; and

WHEREAS, May 7, 2025, marks the fiftieth anniversary of the end of the Vietnam War; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee has always treasured her veterans and their many contributions to our continued liberty, safety, and welfare, and thus it comes as no surprise that in 2008, the Volunteer State became the first state in the nation to pass legislation observing Vietnam Veterans Day; and

WHEREAS, the United States first became involved in Vietnam on November 1, 1955, when President Dwight D. Eisenhower committed military advisors to educate and train the Army of the Republic of Vietnam, actions that marked the official beginning of American involvement in the Vietnam War; and

WHEREAS, Specialist 4 James T. "Tom" Davis, a native of Livingston, was the first American soldier killed in ground combat during the Vietnam War. Serving with the U.S. Army Security Agency's 3rd Radio Research Unit, Specialist 4 Davis was engaged in a mission to locate enemy radio transmitters when his convoy was ambushed by Viet Cong forces on December 22, 1961, near Saigon; his bravery and ultimate sacrifice marked a significant moment in the early stages of American involvement in Vietnam; and

WHEREAS, in recognition of his service and sacrifice, the U.S. Army named the 3rd Radio Research Unit's headquarters at Tan Son Nhut Air Base "Davis Station" in his honor.

President Lyndon B. Johnson later referred to Tom Davis as "the first American to fall in defense of our freedom in Vietnam," underscoring the profound impact of his contribution to our nation's history; and

WHEREAS, on January 12, 1962, United States Army pilots lifted more than 1,000 South Vietnamese service members over jungle and underbrush to capture a National Liberation Front stronghold near Saigon. Operation Chopper marked America's first combat mission against the Viet Cong and the beginning of one of our longest and most challenging wars; and

WHEREAS, through more than a decade of conflict that tested the fabric of our nation, the service of our men and women in uniform stood true. More than sixty years after that fateful mission, we honor the Americans who served, pay tribute to those we have laid to rest, and reaffirm our dedication to showing a generation of veterans the respect and support of a grateful nation; and

WHEREAS, the Vietnam War is a story of service members of different backgrounds, colors, and creeds who came together to complete a daunting mission; it is a story of patriots who braved the line of fire, who cast themselves into harm's way to save a friend, and who fought hour after hour, day after day, to preserve the liberties we hold dear while upholding the highest traditions of our Armed Forces; and

WHEREAS, 9,087,000 personnel served from August 5, 1964, to May 7, 1975, and 2,709,918 personnel served on the ground in Vietnam; two-thirds of those who served were volunteers and not drafted, and 11,000 women served in Vietnam in various roles, including nursing, the Red Cross, and other military roles; and

WHEREAS, more than 2.5 million personnel served in the Republic of South Vietnam, including 1,736,000 in the Army, 391,000 in the Marines, 174,000 in the Navy and Coast Guard, and 293,000 in the Air Force; and

WHEREAS, there are 6.6 million Vietnam War veterans still living, and one in every three males over the age of sixty-five is a Vietnam War veteran; the second-largest Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter in the nation is in Chattanooga, which has more than 1,000 members; and

WHEREAS, half a century after the official end of the Vietnam War on May 7, 1975, we pay tribute to the fallen, the missing, the wounded, the millions who served, and the millions more who awaited their return. Our nation stands stronger for their service, and we honor their proud legacy with our deepest gratitude; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that as we commemorate the fiftieth anniversary of the end of the Vietnam War, we honor and commend our nation's Vietnam War veterans, thank them for their service to this great nation, and extend to them our best wishes for every continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.